



MOUNTAIN WEATHER, TOLD STRAIGHT.

YAMANOUCHI, JP · WINTER 2025-26 OUTLOOK

What it feelzlike for winter in Yamanouchi.

After two warm starts in a row, the Sea of Japan is finally cold enough to do its job. The long-range guidance from JMA points to a near-normal winter on temperature and a slightly snowier-than-average one on precipitation, with the heaviest cycles concentrated in late January and through February. Shiga Kogen should be skiing top to bottom by Christmas, and the high country at Yokoteyama-Shibutoge should hold powder well into March. The monkeys, as ever, will be unbothered.

THE SEASON AT A GLANCE

DECEMBER

The opening

Lifts begin spinning in early December. Cover is thin and patchy until the first proper Sea of Japan cycle, usually around the 15th. By Christmas week, Shiga Kogen's central area is normally fully open and Okushiga is groomed end to end.

JANUARY

The cold settles in

Daily highs above the village rarely climb above zero. Snow comes in long, quiet cycles rather than single dumps. Kumanoyu and Yokoteyama-Shibutoge are the cold-snow benchmarks. Lunar New Year travellers begin arriving from late January.

FEBRUARY

The deep month

The heaviest snow of the year and the busiest fortnight of the season. Lunar New Year drives international demand; Japanese half-term break drives domestic. Powder mornings at Yakebitaiyama and Okushiga are the headline experience.

MARCH

Sun and corn

Days lengthen, the sun gains real warmth, and the snow softens by lunchtime. The high country at Yokoteyama-Shibutoge holds winter conditions; the lower lifts at Sun Valley turn slushy. Onsen-and-ski combinations are at their best.

FEBRUARY SPOTLIGHT

February: the month Yamanouchi delivers.

If a winter trip to Japan only gets one month, this is the one. The Siberian high parks itself over the continent, the Sea of Japan stays warm enough to feed moisture into every cold front, and Shiga Kogen sits directly in the firing line. Modelling has the heaviest cycle of the season landing in week two, with two more cycles either side. Lunar New Year falls on 17 February in 2026, which means the village fills up from the 14th and stays full until the 22nd. Book the front and back ends of the month if you want the snow without the crowds.

SUN 1 TO SAT 7 FEB

The locals' week.

Cold and consistent. A weak front mid-week tops up cover at Okushiga and Yakebitaiyama before the bigger cycle arrives. Lift queues are short, restaurants are quiet, and the central Shiga loop bus runs to a relaxed timetable. The week most repeat visitors quietly recommend.

New snow	20-35cm across the week
Crowds	Quiet, locals and early bookers
Best for	Tree runs, long groomers, onsen evenings

SUN 8 TO SAT 14 FEB

The big cycle.

The heaviest stretch of the season on current modelling. A deep low parks south of Hokkaido and feeds Sea of Japan moisture into the Shiga ridgeline for three or four days. Expect 60 to 90cm at higher elevations, with knee-deep mornings at Yakebitaiyama and Okushiga and an excellent powder window at Yokoteyama-Shibutoge.

New snow	60-90cm Mon to Thu
Crowds	Moderate, building toward Lunar New Year
Best for	Powder mornings, gondola laps

SUN 15 TO SAT 21 FEB

Lunar New Year.

International arrivals peak. Yudanaka and Shibu Onsen book out from the 14th, and the Snow Monkey Park sees its busiest week of the year. On the hill, expect longer gondola queues at Yakebitaiyama and Ryuoo, easing markedly midweek and at the quieter sub-areas like Kumanoyu and Higashidateyama.

New snow	15-30cm midweek top-up
Crowds	Heavy, especially weekends
Best for	Quiet sub-areas, early starts, onsen towns

SUN 22 TO SAT 28 FEB

Powder, second helping.

International crowds thin from the 23rd. Modelling shows a second meaningful cycle around 25 to 26 February with another 30 to 50cm. The combination of fresh snow and emptying slopes makes this the best-value week of the month for travellers who can stay flexible.

New snow	30-50cm Wed to Thu
Crowds	Easing fast after Lunar New Year
Best for	Powder, value, fewer queues

MOUNTAIN BY MOUNTAIN

Shiga Kogen central

Opens Sat 6 Dec

180-260cm by late February

The biggest interconnected ski area in Japan. One lift pass, eighteen sub-areas, and a free shuttle bus tying them together. Easy to lose a day exploring without skiing the same run twice.

Yakebitaiyama

Opens Sat 6 Dec

200-280cm by late February

The Prince-run jewel of Shiga. Two gondolas, the 1998 Olympic GS course, and consistently the deepest cover in the central area. The default choice for international visitors.

Okushiga Kogen

Opens Sat 13 Dec

220-300cm by late February

The quietest, longest groomers in the range and the powder pocket of Shiga. End of the road, both literally and metaphorically. Worth the extra bus ride from the central loop.

Yokoteyama-Shibutoge

Opens Sat 22 Nov

150-220cm by late February

Honshu's highest lift-served terrain and the first Yamanouchi resort to open. Cold, exposed, and often the best snow in the country in mid-winter. Closes overnight in storms.

HOW WE FORECAST

How we built this read.

This outlook combines the Japan Meteorological Agency's three-month seasonal forecast with snow depth records from the Shiga Kogen Tourist Association, the resorts' own opening schedules, and our own pattern-matching against the last fifteen Yamanouchi winters. We also lean on Snow Japan's network of local observers, which is the closest thing the Japanese alps has to a community snow report. We don't run our own model. What we do is read the same public sources every serious snow watcher reads, then write the result in plain English. Where a number is a target, not a measurement, we say so. Where the modelling is uncertain, we say that too.

SOURCES

Japan Meteorological Agency seasonal outlook	Temperature and precipitation trend for Honshu and the Sea of Japan side for Dec-Feb
Shiga Kogen Tourist Association snow report	Daily snow depth at Sun Valley, Ichinose, Hasuike, Okushiga, and the central area
Prince Snow Resorts (Yakebitaiyama)	Stated opening dates, lift status, snow-making capacity at Yakebitai
Snow Japan resort tracker	Crowd-sourced snow conditions across Yamanouchi and the wider Nagano region
Nagano Prefecture road conditions	Winter road status and overnight closures on Route 292 and the Shiga Kusatsu Highway over Shibutoge
JNTO and Yamanouchi Tourism Association	Expected visitor patterns around Lunar New Year and the Japanese half-term break

Numbers in this preview are sample figures used to illustrate format. Production sends will carry the latest values from the sources above.

PLAN AHEAD

Lift passes

The Shiga Kogen all-mountain pass is cheaper than buying single sub-areas after day two. The Prince pass covers Yakebitaiyama and Karuizawa.

Accommodation

Shibu Onsen and Yudanaka book out for the week of Lunar New Year (14-22 Feb). Nakano City and Iiyama still have rooms during peak.

Driving and transport

The Hokuriku Shinkansen to Nagano then Nagaden Yudanaka line is faster than driving from Tokyo. Hire cars require winter tyres from December.

Snow Monkey Park

Open year-round. Coldest mornings see the most monkeys in the bath. Buy timed entry online during Lunar New Year week to skip the queue.

[Open Yamanouchi →](#)

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